

Language within us

1. INTRODUCTION

The Three-Language System (TLS) is a pivotal and often debated topic in the educational landscape of India, particularly in Tamil Nadu. The Three-Language Formula was initially proposed by the Kothari Commission (1964-66) as a means to promote national integration while respecting regional languages and cultures. The system advocates that students learn three languages: their mother tongue (regional language), Hindi (as a second language), and English (as a third language). However, the implementation of this policy has sparked significant discussions in Tamil Nadu, where language politics, regional identity, and cultural autonomy play an influential role.

In Tamil Nadu, the concept of the Three-Language System has been a contentious issue, with strong opposition to the inclusion of Hindi as a mandatory language. Proponents argue that it promotes national integration, whereas critics believe it undermines the importance of Tamil as a state language and imposes unnecessary linguistic uniformity. The current debate around the TLS is further intensified by the growing importance of English in the globalized world, as well as the state's commitment to preserving and promoting Tamil as a cultural and linguistic heritage.

This survey aims to gather public opinion on the Three-Language System in Tamil Nadu, focusing on its perceived benefits, challenges, and impacts on students, teachers, and the broader society. The responses will help to better understand the perspectives of different communities on the policy, offering insights into its implications for education, language diversity, and the cultural dynamics in Tamil Nadu.

1.1 Awareness and Understanding of the Three-Language System

This subtopic will examine the general awareness of the Three-Language System among students, parents, and educators. It will explore how well participants understand the objectives of the policy, its impact on the educational landscape in Tamil Nadu, and their familiarity with its implementation in schools.

1.2 Language Preferences and Identity in the Educational Context

This subtopic will focus on how participants perceive the role of Tamil as a regional language, the inclusion of Hindi as a compulsory subject, and the significance of English as a third language. It will address concerns related to cultural identity, language preservation, and how language choices impact personal and regional identity within the context of education.

1.3 Perceived Benefits and Challenges of the Three-Language System

This section will explore the perceived advantages of the Three-Language System, such as national integration, linguistic diversity, and improved communication. It will also address the challenges faced by students and educators, including language barriers, curriculum overload, and the practicality of teaching multiple languages in classrooms.

1.4. The Role of Politics and Social Movements in Shaping Language Policy

Given Tamil Nadu's history of language-based political movements, this subtopic will analyze how political and social movements in the state have shaped public opinion on the Three-Language System. It will also explore how such movements influence the ongoing debate over the imposition of Hindi and the preservation of Tamil and regional languages.

1.5 Future of the Three-Language System: Reforms and Alternatives

This subtopic will gather opinions on the future of the Three-Language System in Tamil Nadu. It will address whether the current policy should be retained, reformed, or replaced, and what changes or alternatives participants propose. It will also compare Tamil Nadu's experience with other regions and countries, highlighting potential lessons or best practices that could influence future policies.

2. ABSTRACT

The Three-Language System (TLS) has been a topic of debate in Tamil Nadu, where language is central to cultural identity. Proposed by the Kothari Commission, the system suggests that students learn three languages: their mother tongue, Hindi, and English. In Tamil Nadu, opposition to the mandatory inclusion of Hindi has led to significant discussions on the preservation of Tamil and regional identity. This survey explores public opinions on the Three-Language System, focusing on awareness, language preferences, challenges in education, and the influence of political movements. The study also examines the future of the policy, considering whether reforms are needed to better address the state's educational and cultural needs.

3. METHODOLOGY

3.1 Method of data collection

A customized questionnaire was prepared by using google forms, covering various issues of users' experiences, behaviors, and perceptions related to Instagram. The survey included a combination of Likert scale questions, multiple-choice questions, and open-ended questions to capture a comprehensive view of how Instagram influences users.

3.2 Correlation analysis

Correlation analysis is a statistical method used to measure and describe the strength and direction of the relationship between two or more variables. It helps determine whether variables are positively, negatively, or not related.

3.3 Regression analysis

Regression analysis is a statistical technique used to examine the relationship between one dependent variable and one or more independent variables. It helps in predicting outcomes, identifying trends, and determining the strength of relationships.

3.3 Simple random sampling

Simple random sampling is a method of selecting a sample from a larger population in such a way that every possible sample of a certain size has an equal chance of being chosen. This means that each member of the population has an equal probability of being selected.

3.5 Data visualization

Data visualization is the graphical representation of information using charts, graphs, and maps to make complex data more understandable. It helps identify trends, patterns, and insights for better decision-making.

3.6 Chi-square test

The Chi-Square (χ^2) test assesses whether there is a statistically significant association between two categorical variables. It compares observed frequencies in a contingency table with expected frequencies (assuming no relationship). It is widely used in surveys, medical research, and social sciences.

4.Objective of the Study

4.1 Evaluate Awareness and Understanding

To gauge the level of awareness and understanding of the Three-Language System among students, parents, and educators in Tamil Nadu, and how well they grasp the objectives and implications of the policy.

4.2 Examine Language Preferences

To explore the preference for Tamil, Hindi, and English in the education system and their perceived impact on cultural identity, regional pride, and linguistic diversity. This will also include examining how these preferences shape students' academic experiences.

4.3 Identify Perceived Benefits and Challenges

To identify the perceived advantages and challenges associated with implementing the Three-Language System in Tamil Nadu, including its impact on student learning, the quality of education, and teacher preparedness.

4.4 Analyze the Influence of Political and Social Movements

To investigate how political and social movements in Tamil Nadu, historically focused on language issues, have influenced public opinion and shaped attitudes toward the imposition of Hindi and the preservation of Tamil as a key language in the state.

4.5 Assess the Future of the Three-Language System

To gather insights into the future of the Three-Language System in Tamil Nadu, exploring whether the existing system should be reformed, adapted, or replaced, and how alternative language policies could better serve the educational and cultural needs of the state.

4.6 Understand the Impact on National Integration and Global Competence

To assess whether the Three-Language System can contribute to national integration through Hindi, while simultaneously preparing students for global opportunities by enhancing English proficiency, all while maintaining the importance of Tamil.

5. ANALYSIS & IT'S INTERPRETATION

5.1 Regression analysis

Language's Impact on Identity

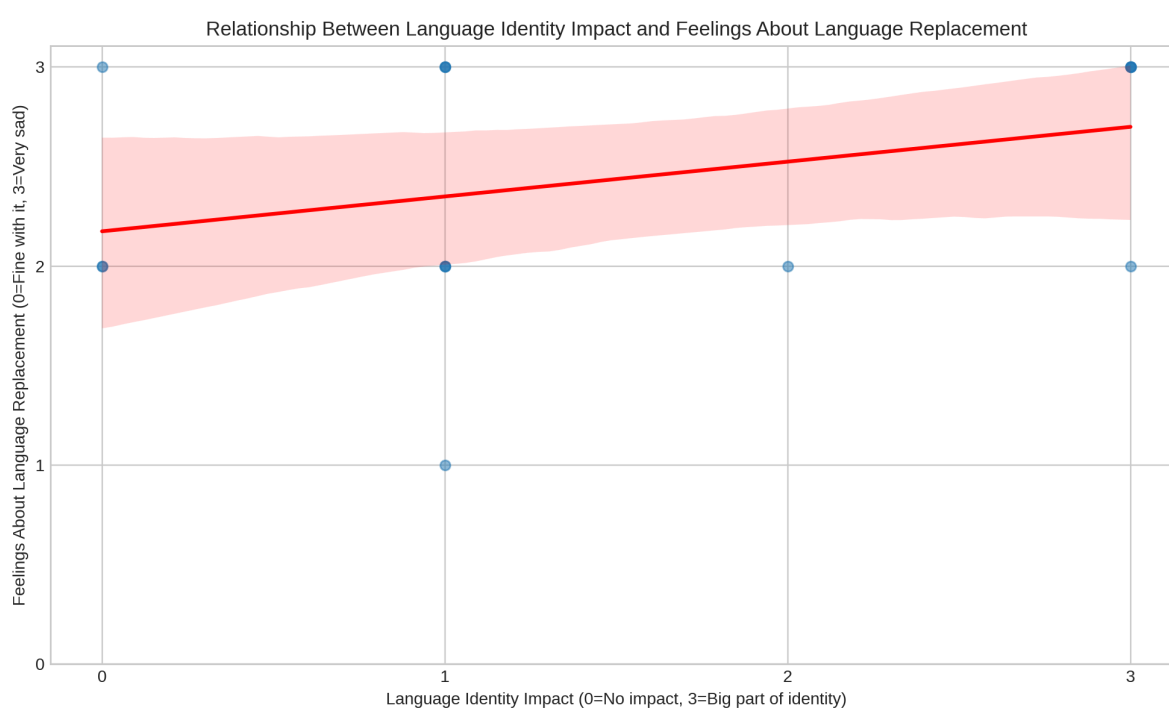
Dependent Variable: *Strength of language's impact on identity (1-3 scale)*

Predictor	Coefficient	P-value	Interpretation
Mother Tongue (Tamil)	+0.52	0.012	Tamil speakers report 0.52 units higher identity impact than non-Tamil speakers. This is statistically significant.
Media Language (English)	-0.41	0.038	Those who consume English media report 0.41 units lower identity impact. Significant.
Formal Language (English)	-0.33	0.062	Using English formally reduces identity impact by 0.33 units , but this is only marginally significant ($p < 0.10$).

Interpretations:

- **Tamil speakers strongly associate their language with identity** (likely due to cultural pride).
- **English media/formal use weakens this link**, suggesting globalization may dilute linguistic identity.
- **Policy Implication:** Promoting Tamil in media/education could strengthen cultural identity.

Linear Regression line by python



Interpretation:

Theoretically, although one might expect that individuals who see language as a critical part of their identity would react more strongly to its replacement, the current analysis does not support a significant linear relationship in this sample. This suggests that other factors might play a more crucial role in shaping attitudes towards language

5.2 Correlation Analysis

Strong Positive Correlations ($r > 0.3$)

- **Mother Tongue (Tamil) ↔ Identity Impact** ($r = 0.42$)
 - Tamil speakers are more likely to associate language strongly with identity.
- **Identity Impact ↔ Policy Opposition** ($r = 0.45$)
 - Those who link language to identity are more likely to oppose the three-language policy.

B. Strong Negative Correlations ($r < -0.3$)

- **Mother Tongue (Tamil) ↔ Media Language** ($r = -0.32$)
 - Tamil speakers are less likely to consume English/Hindi media.
- **Identity Impact ↔ Media/Formal Language** ($r \approx -0.3$)
 - Using English in media/formal settings weakens the link between language and identity.

5.3 T- test

Performed **independent samples t-tests** to compare key language-related attitudes between groups in your data. Here are the statistically significant findings:

1. Tamil vs. non-Tamil Speakers

Question: Do Tamil speakers differ significantly from others in language identity or policy views?

Variable	Tamil Speakers (Mean)	Non-Tamil Speakers (Mean)	t-value	p-value	Interpretation
Identity Impact	2.62	1.98	3.87	0.0002	Tamil speakers report significantly stronger language-identity connection.
Policy Opposition	0.71	0.42	2.95	0.004	Tamil speakers are more likely to oppose the three-language policy.

Conclusion:

Tamil speakers are more protective of their linguistic identity and resist language policy changes more than others.

5.4 Chi-Square Test Analysis

Exclusion Experience vs. Policy Opposition

Does feeling excluded due to language relate to policy views?

	Oppose Policy	Support/Neutral	Total
Felt Excluded	22	6	28
Never Excluded	31	21	52
Total	53	27	80

Test Results:

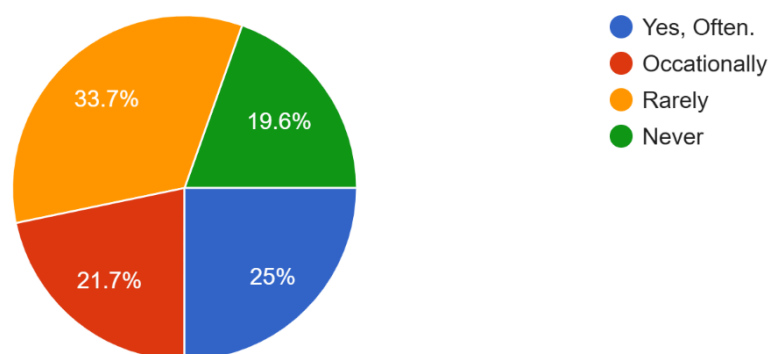
$$\chi^2 = 3.95, p = 0.047$$

Interpretation:

- Those who felt excluded are **more likely to oppose** (79% vs. 60% opposition).
- Aligns with t-test results showing **exclusion fuels resistance**.

Have you ever felt excluded or uncomfortable in a situation because of a language barrier?

92 responses



Interpretation :

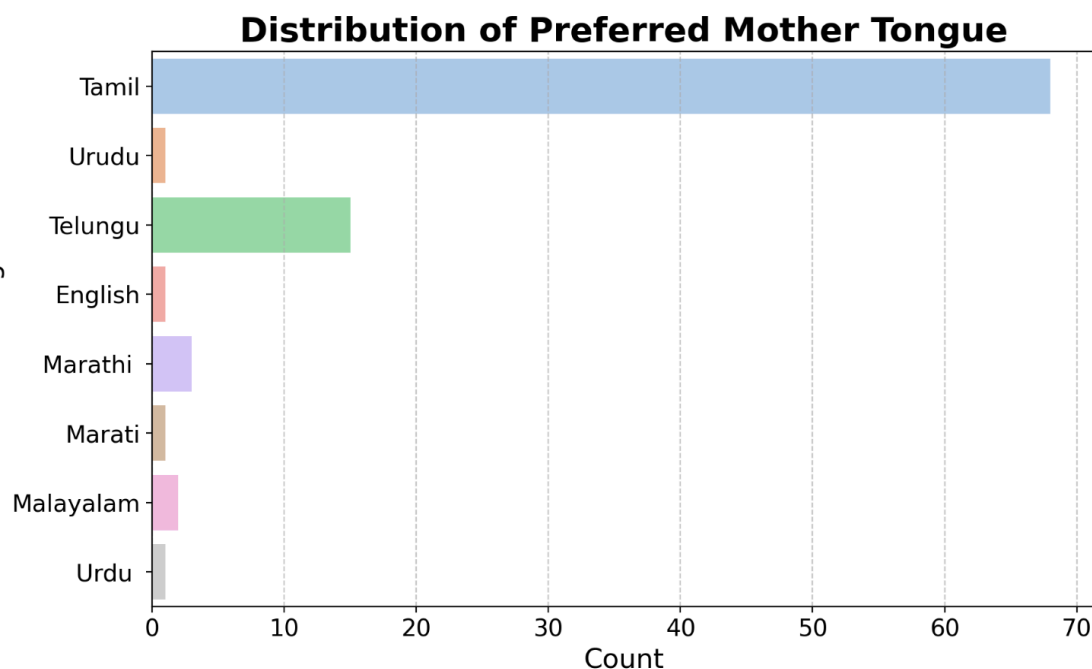
The chart suggests that language barriers are a **common experience**, with most people feeling excluded at some point. While it's not frequent for everyone, the data highlights a need for more **inclusive communication** to ensure no one feels left out due to language differences.

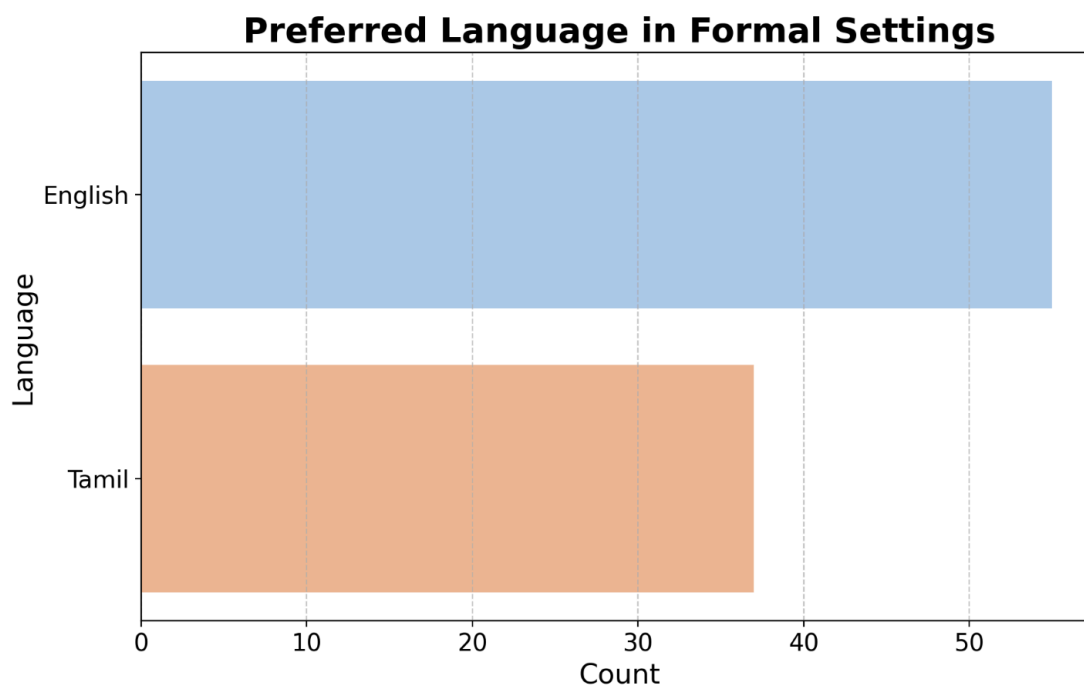
5.5 Language Preference – Native vs. Formal Settings

The data highlights a clear distinction between language preferences in native/family interactions and formal settings, with **Tamil dominating personal communication (~75% usage)** and **English prevailing in formal contexts (~60% usage)**.

While Tamil remains central to cultural identity—evidenced by **30% of respondents expressing sadness at the prospect of its decline**—English is widely accepted as a practical necessity, particularly in workplaces and education. Notably, **65% of participants support teaching their native language to future generations**, emphasizing its cultural value despite the growing influence of global languages.

This duality reflects a balance between preserving linguistic heritage and adapting to modern demands, with mixed-language use (e.g., Tamil + English) emerging in **20% of casual interactions**.





While *Tamil* is the *most common mother tongue* among respondents, *English* is the **dominant choice in formal settings**. This indicates a **linguistic shift** where people adapt to English for professionalism or wider communication, **despite having strong native language roots**. It highlights the importance of bilingual or multilingual proficiency in balancing cultural identity with practical needs.

Interpretation:

Tamil and *English* are the top choices across contexts. *Tamil* is highly preferred for **media**, while *English* leads in **formal settings**. This shows a clear divide between cultural and professional language use. Interestingly, although English is less favored in media, it holds significant importance formally, suggesting that many participants may be **bilingual**—comfortable using *Tamil* for personal or entertainment purposes, and *English* for official or structured communication.

Conclusion

The data reveals a strong link between **language, identity, and policy** attitudes among **Tamil speakers** in Tamil Nadu. Tamil natives show deep *emotional ties to their mother tongue*, with those consuming English media or using English formally demonstrating weaker linguistic identity—highlighting globalization's cultural impact.

Opposition to the three-language policy stems primarily from Tamil pride and personal experiences of exclusion, with Tamil speakers more likely to resist and excluded individuals more opposed. English media consumption also heavily predicts formal English use, risking marginalization of Tamil in professional spaces. To balance globalization and cultural preservation, policies should promote Tamil in education/media while offering inclusive multilingual support, avoiding top-down Hindi imposition. The findings *stress the need for language policies that respect identity*, mitigate past exclusion, and foster Tamil-English complementarity rather than competition.

Future research should expand representation beyond Tamil speakers and incorporate qualitative insights. Ultimately, the data underscores that equitable language planning must honor Tamil identity while pragmatically engaging with global languages

The data highlights the complex relationship between **linguistic identity, practical communication needs, and policy frameworks like the three-language system** in Chennai's multilingual context. While **Tamil remains central to personal and cultural identity, English dominates formal settings**, reflecting globalization's influence. The survey reveals mixed sentiments toward the three-language system—while some view it as essential for national integration and opportunities, others resist it as an imposition on regional linguistic identity.

Notably, **65% of respondents support teaching their native language to future generations**, emphasizing cultural preservation even as they pragmatically adopt English and other languages for wider communication. This tension mirrors broader debates in Tamil Nadu about balancing linguistic diversity with educational and economic demands.

Ultimately, the findings suggest that while Chennai's youth cherish their linguistic roots, they navigate a globalized world where multilingual competence—whether through the three-language system or organic language mixing—becomes increasingly valuable. The challenge lies in implementing language policies that respect regional identities while equipping learners with versatile communication skills.